

Statement of Purpose

When I was constantly exposed to advertisements on Chinese e-commerce platforms, I often felt uneasy about claims like “whitening miracles” or “overnight weight loss.” I couldn’t explain why at first, but later I realized these one-way messages treated consumers as if they had no judgment of their own. I noticed a similar problem in live streaming on TikTok, where anchors used hype and flash sales to create temporary hits. The numbers looked good, but behind them were high return rates and low loyalty. That made me wonder if marketing could be more sustainable. I began imagining an approach that uses data to understand people better rather than manipulate them. If social media data could be analyzed with tools like SPSS to find patterns in consumer psychology, marketing decisions could be guided by evidence instead of guesswork. This idea made me see marketing as both an art and a science, and it motivated me to pursue graduate study in this field.

My undergraduate studies gave me a strong foundation to think critically about media and marketing. In the course Build Public: Use Social Media, I came to realize that advertising is never just about products, it also shapes social values and norms. One example that struck me was Florasis, a Chinese beauty brand that once promoted a lip product as a way to “gain sexual attractiveness.” Instead of building positive brand equity, it reinforced stereotypes. In contrast, Dove’s “Real Beauty” campaign encouraged inclusivity and body positivity, showing me how marketing can strengthen trust and long-term relationships. Later, in Media & Promotionalism, I studied Estée Lauder’s Advanced Night Repair. I discovered that while its image of maturity resonated with older consumers, it created a sense of “aging distance” for Gen Z. The problem wasn’t the product itself but the narrow narrative that emphasized tradition and anti-aging. This finding surprised me. It made me realize how easily a strong brand can lose touch with younger consumers if it fails to refresh its story. Experiences like these convinced me that successful marketing depends on consumer insight, not just creative messaging.

My internship at Trip.com gave me a chance to apply what I had learned. I initially focused on promoting cheap flights, thinking price was the main factor that drove user engagement. But after tracking campaign data, I found that posts highlighting comfort and experience actually converted better. I adjusted our strategy around the idea of “affordable luxury travel,” and one campaign received over 10,000 interactions and generated about RMB 200,000 in sales. More important than the results was what I learned from the process: creativity draws attention, but data proves what truly works. I also realized that data is most powerful when combined with human understanding. In team discussions, I used consumer behavior data to support design and product decisions, helping bridge creative ideas with real user needs.

The MSc in Marketing program at HKUST attracts me because it offers exactly this balance between analytical and human perspectives. Courses such as Marketing Analytics and Understanding Consumers will help me connect data interpretation with cultural and psychological insight. I hope to learn advanced methods like data mining and machine learning while also understanding how emotions and values shape decision-making. Hong Kong’s position as a bridge between Eastern and Western markets makes HKUST the ideal place to study these dynamics and explore marketing within an international yet culturally grounded context.

My goal is to become a marketing professional who uses both data and empathy to build meaningful brand strategies. In the long term, I want to help global companies grow in Asia by aligning international vision with local behavior. I know this will be challenging, especially mastering new analytical tools, but I see it as a path of growth. With its strong curriculum and global environment, HKUST’s MSc in Marketing program will give me the knowledge and confidence to achieve that goal.